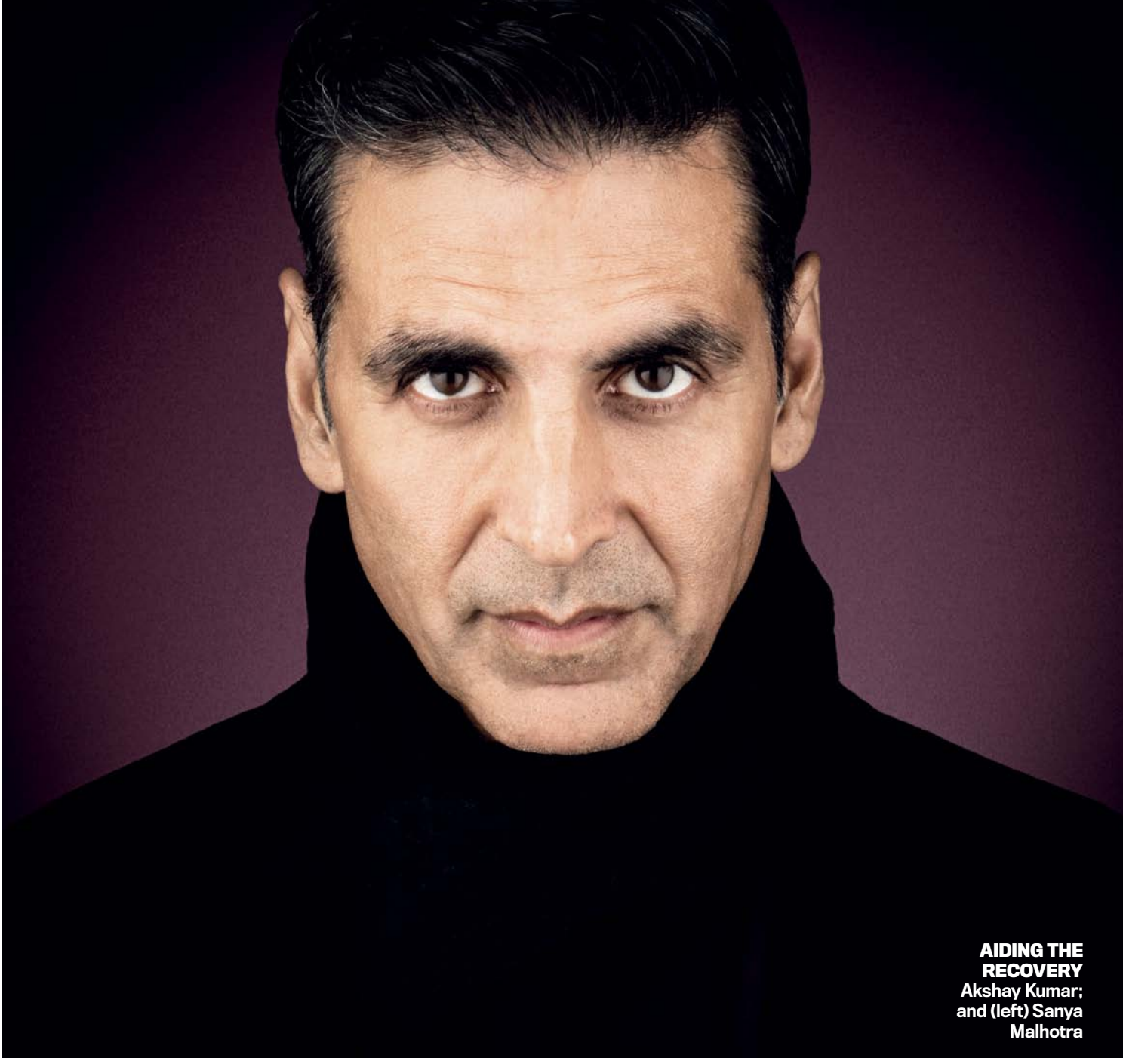


AIDING THE RECOVERY
Akshay Kumar; and (left) Sanya Malhotra

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

to make film watching a communal experience again. Then came the deadly second wave of Covid-19 and theatre owners were, once again, reeling under the lockdown.

The scenario was particularly bleak in Hindi-speaking territories. Salman Khan took his Eid release *Radhe* straight to digital, a decision that most audiences approved especially after seeing the loud, mess of an action film. Where Salman failed, Sidharth Malhotra succeeded. His *Shershaah*, a biopic of Kargil martyr Captain Vikram Batra, became Prime Video's most watched film. Some producers, though, held on to their films, skipping a digital release. The one that patiently waited for the longest was rewarded the most. Kumar's *Sooryavanshi*, which was originally intended for a March 2020 release, finally arrived in theatres on November 5, 2021, and within a week became the first Hindi film in 18 months to cross the Rs 100 crore mark. It was a return to form for Kumar who was back to his prolific ways, shooting seven films in the midst of a pandemic—*BellBottom*, *Atrangi Re*, *Bachchan Pandey*, *Raksha Bandhan*, *OMG2*, *Ram Setu* and a Jackky Bhagnani produced action thriller. By doing so, he ensured that work flows in an industry which has only now begun to recover from the blow of the pandemic.

Sooryavanshi's success—Rs 196 crore in India—with cinemas in a key market like Maharashtra still running at 50 per cent occupancy is the elixir that cinema owners in the